SOP-GOV-002 · GitHub collaboration: organisations, teams, issues, discussions, pull requests, projects, Pages

SOP GOV-002 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-01 | For Stewards and members

Department: GOV · **ID:** 002 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** the organisation's owners; the steward executes · **Last changed:** 2026-11-01

Purpose

One page that says what each GitHub collaboration tool is for in this organisation, who may use it, and how access is decided: by **teams**, with the organisation's **base permission set to No permission**, so that a private repository is read only by the people a team names.

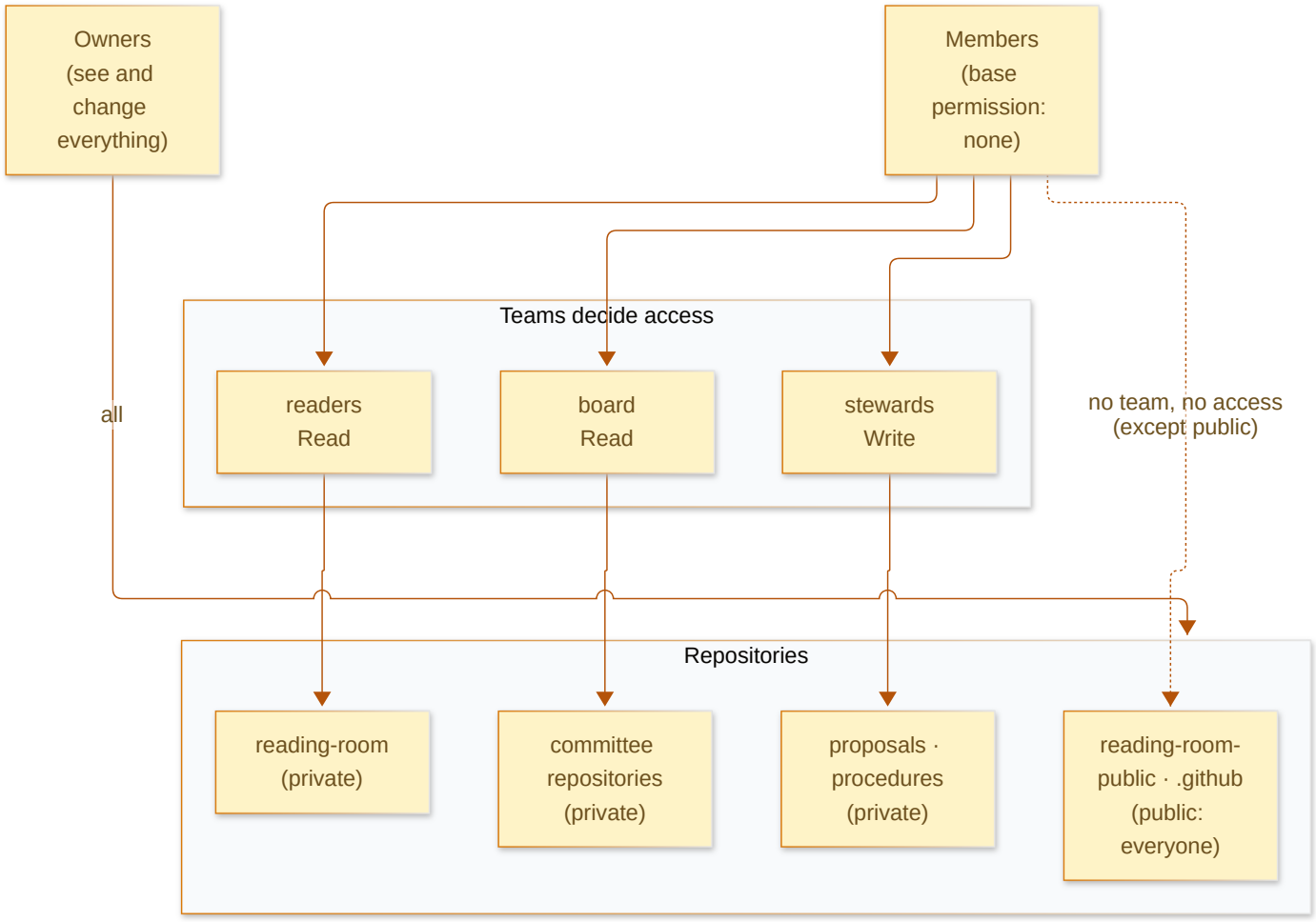
Scope

The organisation's GitHub space: owners, members, outside collaborators, teams, and the tools on each repository. Not credentials (SOP-IT-002), not the road a change travels (SOP-OPS-001/002), not board membership itself (SOP-GOV-001).

Roles

Role	Does
Owner	full control: settings, billing, base permission, teams, invitations. Two or more, so no single person is a point of failure
Member	belongs to the organisation; reads and writes **only** what their teams grant (base permission none)
Team maintainer	adds and removes people in one team, on an officer's yes
Outside collaborator	not a member; granted one repository at a time; use sparingly
Helper	works through a person's own access or an approved connection; opens pull requests, never merges

How access is decided



Base permission: No permission, and why

The **base permission** is what every member gets on every repository before any team is counted. GitHub's default for a new organisation is **Read**: every member can read every private repository. That quietly defeats a readers team or a board team, because a member outside the team can read the repository anyway.

The fleet sets it to **No permission**:

- **Teams become the truth.** A member reads a private repository only through a team that names it; a page that lists a team's repositories lists exactly who can read them.
- **Owners are unaffected.** They keep full access.
- **Public repositories stay public** to everyone, signed in or not.
- **Before switching, put every member in a team** that grants what they need. A member in no team loses access to every private repository the moment it changes. Hold the switch for that organisation until they are placed.

> ***Note. Where the heads-up came from.*** *The session's "You should know" reader (SOP-IT-003 describes it) pointed out on 2026-11-01 that the fleet's organisations still had base permission* ***Read****, so the readers and board teams were not actually gating anything for members. The lab steward switched the organisations to* ***No permission*** *the same day, holding one until its member was placed in a team.*

Set it (an owner's action; settings → Member privileges → Base permissions, or):

```
gh api orgs/theholyearthfoundation --jq .default_repository_permission                  # read it first
gh api -X PATCH orgs/theholyearthfoundation -f default_repository_permission=none       # then set it
```

You should see: `none` when you read it again.

The tools, one by one

Tool	Use it for	Who	Notes
Organisation	the house: its people, teams and repositories under one name	owners	free plan; GitHub for Nonprofits gives Team free once incorporation is confirmed
Teams	who reads or writes what: `readers`, `board`, `stewards`, one per committee	owners, team maintainers	**closed** (visible to members) is the default; **secret** only when the team's existence is itself private
Issues	one question, task or decision per thread; "yes / not yet" on a proposal	anyone with Read on the repository	title with the proposal or SOP number; close it when answered
Discussions	open conversation that is not a task: ideas, introductions, Q&A	members, when switched on	switch on per repository (Settings → Features) or for the organisation; move a discussion to an issue when it becomes a task
Pull requests	a change asking to move (`preview` → `main` is a **Promote**)	helpers and members open; a person with the role merges	**merge commit only**, never squash (SOP-OPS-002)
Projects	a board of issues and pull requests across repositories: what is waiting, moving, done	members	optional; a board is a view, the issues stay the truth
Pages	a website from a repository: the public reading room, a site's live and rehearsal lanes	owners switch it on	on the free plan Pages publishes from **public** repositories, and a Pages site is **public**; members-only sites need Enterprise Cloud
The `.github` profile	the organisation's front door: banner, welcome deck, links	owners	public; carries only welcome decks and links

The Holy Earth Foundation today (read 2026-11-01)

	Setting	Read back
	Owners	two: the lab steward (Christopher) and the founder (Kenney, project lead)
	Base permission	`none`, set 2026-11-01
	Teams	`readers` (closed): Read on `reading-room` only. No `board` or `stewards` team yet (SOP-GOV-001 creates `board` when the officers name the first member)

	Plan	free (GitHub for Nonprofits waits on incorporation)
	Pages	the portal (`theholyearthfoundation.github.io`), the public reading room, the sites' live and rehearsal lanes, the changelog

Both members are owners, so the switch to `none` changed nothing for them; it matters from the first member who is not an owner. The spiritual source the foundation names is Jesus and the Holy Spirit; on GitHub the decisions are made by people with a role, named per item (the founder as project lead, the lab steward, the foundation's officers), and one day perhaps by a DAO.

Steps: steward, once per organisation

1. Two owners at least. *You should see:* two names under People → Role: Owner.
2. Create the teams (closed): `gh api -X POST orgs/theholyearthfoundation/teams -f name=readers -f privacy=closed` (and `board`, `stewards` as needed). *You should see:* each on the Teams page.
3. Grant each team its repositories (SOP-GOV-001 and SOP-IT-002 have the commands; `permission=pull` is Read, `push` is Write).
4. Place every member in at least one team. *You should see:* `gh api --paginate orgs/theholyearthfoundation/members --jq '.[].login'` and the union of the teams' members agree.
5. Set the base permission to none (above). *You should see:* `none`.
6. Set merge commits only on the proposals and procedures repositories (SOP-OPS-002). Switch on Discussions where people want them.
7. Ask one member (not an owner) to open one private link they should see and one they should not. *You should see:* the first opens, the second is a 404.

Verification

`gh api orgs/theholyearthfoundation --jq .default_repository_permission` prints `none`; every member is in a team; a member's own test (step 7) matches the teams page.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
A member suddenly sees 404 on a repository they used to read	base permission switched to none and they are in no team that grants it	add them to the right team; never switch the base back to Read to "fix" one person
A member reads a repository no team grants	base permission is still Read, or they are an outside collaborator on it	read the base permission; check the repository's Collaborators page
Discussions tab missing	not switched on	Settings → Features → Discussions
Pages on a private repository will not switch on	the free plan publishes Pages only from public repositories	publish from the public twin instead (SOP-OPS-003)

Related

- SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* · SOP-GOV-001 *Board reading room membership* · SOP-IT-002 *Reading room and helper access*
- SOP-OPS-002 *Pull requests and Promotes* · SOP-OPS-003 *Private houses everything, public lanes witness*
- `my-template/walkthroughs/ORG-SECURITY-SETTINGS.md`, `my-template/NAMES-POLICY.md`

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-11-01	Drafted: the tools one by one, access by teams, base permission none and why (the "You should know" heads-up)	Alfred
2026-11-01	Adopted for The Holy Earth Foundation from the shared template: amber badges and icons, the foundation's login filled in where a page names a real address	Alfred